



A GUIDE FOR EXPATS FROM THE UK AND US

The Relocation Guide

Moving to the Middle East, Africa or Europe

UAE

Saudi Arabia

Oman

Cyprus

Spain

Portugal

Georgia

Africa

A move abroad is a dozen small moves made in the right order.

Your visa decides where you can live. Your tax residency decides where you pay. Your bank, your doctor and your children's school each need paperwork the others depend on.

This guide is written for people leaving the UK or US. It compares destinations first, then works through each part of the move, and ends with a timeline.



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Choosing a destination

Start with how you'll be allowed to stay. The right country is the one with a residency route that fits your work, income and family.

DESTINATION	REGION	COMMON ROUTES	KNOW THIS
UAE	Middle East	Employment, Golden Visa, remote work visa	No personal income tax; health insurance is mandatory in Dubai
Saudi Arabia	Middle East	Employment, Premium Residency	Most work visas are sponsored by your employer
Oman	Middle East	Employment, investor residency	Investor residency can be linked to property ownership
Cyprus	Europe (EU)	Work permit, residency by investment, digital nomad visa	EU member where English is widely spoken
Spain	Europe (EU)	Non-lucrative visa, digital nomad visa, work visa	The property golden visa ended in 2025
Portugal	Europe (EU)	D7 passive income visa, digital nomad visa	Property no longer qualifies for a golden visa
Georgia	Caucasus	Visa-free stay, residence through work or investment	UK and US citizens can stay up to a year without a visa
Africa	Varies	Work permits; some countries offer digital nomad or retirement permits	Rules vary widely. Check each country's immigration office

Visas and residency

Almost every residency permit falls into one of five routes. Find yours, then check the exact requirements with the destination's immigration authority.

ROUTE 1

Employment

Your employer sponsors the visa. It usually ends if the job does, so check how long you have to find new work.

ROUTE 2

Remote work / digital nomad

For people employed or self-employed abroad. Expect a minimum income threshold and proof your work is location-independent.

ROUTE 3

Passive income / retirement

Based on pensions, savings or rental income. Many don't allow you to work locally.

ROUTE 4

Investor / property

Residency in exchange for a qualifying investment. Thresholds and eligible assets change often.

ROUTE 5

Family

Spouses, partners and children join a main visa holder. Bring apostilled marriage and birth certificates.

WARNING

Entering as a tourist does not give you permission to work. Many visas must be applied for from your home country before you move.

Tax residency

Moving your home doesn't automatically move your tax bill. Many countries treat you as tax resident once you spend 183 days there in a year, but your home country has its own rules for when you stop being resident.

LEAVING THE UK

Residence is a test, not a date

- The Statutory Residence Test looks at your days in the UK and your ties to it: home, work and family.
- Tell HMRC you're leaving, usually with form P85 or your Self Assessment return.
- Income from UK property stays taxable in the UK.

LEAVING THE US

Citizens keep filing

- US citizens file a US return wherever they live.
- The Foreign Earned Income Exclusion and foreign tax credits can reduce what you owe.
- Report foreign accounts on an FBAR if they total more than \$10,000 at any point in the year.

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The tax year you move in is the one most people get wrong.

Split-year rules, departure dates and when you start work abroad all change the outcome.

GOOD TO KNOW

The UAE, Saudi Arabia and Oman do not generally tax personal employment income. Check for a double tax treaty between your home country and your destination, and get advice before you leave.

Renting or buying

Most expats rent first. Living in a city for six to twelve months shows you which neighbourhood, commute and building suit you before you commit to buying.



Rent first if

- ✓ You don't know the city yet
- ✓ Your job or visa is on a fixed-term contract
- ✓ You're waiting on school places

Consider buying if

- ✓ You plan to stay five years or more
- ✓ Ownership supports your residency route
- ✓ You've already lived in the area

Buying? Read our companion guide, [The Overseas Buyer's Guide](#).

Cost of living

A lower tax bill or cheaper groceries can be offset by rent, school fees and insurance. Build your budget around the way you actually live.



What to budget for

Housing	Rent, deposit and agency fees. In the Gulf, rent is often paid upfront in a few cheques.
Schools	International school fees are often the largest cost for families.
Healthcare	Private insurance premiums, and any excess you pay per visit.
Transport	Car purchase or lease, licence conversion and fuel.
Utilities	Air conditioning in summer or heating in winter can change bills sharply.
Travel home	Flights for visits, family events and emergencies.

TIP

If you're moving for a job, compare the full package with your current one: housing, schooling and health cover, not only salary.

Banking and money

Local banks usually want a residence ID and a local address, and landlords want a local bank account. Plan for the gap between arriving and having all three.

01

Keep your home account open

You'll need it for pensions, tax refunds and any income at home. Update your address and tell the bank you're moving abroad.

02

Open a multi-currency account before you go

It covers deposits, rent and daily spending in your first weeks, before a local account is ready.

03

Open a local account once you have residency

Bring your passport, residence permit, tenancy contract and, if employed, a salary letter.

04

Move large sums with a specialist

Compare the rate offered with the mid-market rate. The gap is the real fee.

US CITIZENS

FATCA reporting means some foreign banks limit accounts for US persons. Ask before you apply.

FRAUD ALERT

Never pay a rental deposit before you've seen the property or confirmed the landlord's identity.

Healthcare

You leave your home system when you move. Arrange cover that starts the day you arrive, not the day your residency is approved.

GULF STATES

Private insurance

Health insurance is mandatory in Dubai and Saudi Arabia, and employers usually provide it. Check whether your family is covered too.

EU DESTINATIONS

Public, once you're registered

Residents who work or pay in can use the public system. Visa applications often require private cover first.



Before you pack

- ☐ Get copies of medical and vaccination records
- ☐ Bring a doctor's letter for any regular prescriptions
- ☐ Check if any of your medicines are controlled at your destination
- ☐ Confirm your policy covers pre-existing conditions
- ☐ UK state pensioners: ask about the S1 form for EU healthcare

Schools

Good international schools fill up early, and many families choose where to live around the school run. Start here, before you sign a lease.



British curriculum

GCSEs and A levels. The easiest switch for UK families.

American curriculum

High school diploma, often with AP courses.

International Baccalaureate

Recognised worldwide. Useful if you may move again.

APPLY EARLY

Popular schools keep waiting lists. Apply as soon as your move is likely.

CHECK RATINGS

Read inspection reports, such as KHDA ratings in Dubai.

BRING RECORDS

Recent reports, transfer letters and attested certificates where required.

Your moving timeline

Six months is a comfortable lead time. Tick these off in order; later steps often depend on earlier ones.

6 MONTHS BEFORE

- ☐ Choose your visa route
- ☐ Check passports are valid for 6+ months
- ☐ Apply to schools
- ☐ Book tax advice

3 MONTHS BEFORE

- ☐ Submit your visa application
- ☐ Apostille certificates and degrees
- ☐ Get removal quotes
- ☐ Arrange health insurance

1 MONTH BEFORE

- ☐ Book temporary accommodation
- ☐ Tell your tax office and bank
- ☐ Set up mail forwarding
- ☐ Arrange pet travel

FIRST MONTH THERE

- ☐ Complete residency registration and medical
- ☐ Open a local bank account
- ☐ Get a local phone number
- ☐ Convert your driving licence

KEEP IN YOUR HAND LUGGAGE

Passports, visa approvals, attested certificates, employment contract, medical records and prescriptions. Keep a scanned copy of each in the cloud.

NEXT STEP

Talk to an advisor before you commit.

Book a free 30-minute call. We'll review your destination, budget and timeline, and tell you which local specialists you'll need.

Book your free call →

amsispaces.com/consult